

Session 7: Down Into the Pit

Key Takeaways

- The biblical authors liken Yoseph's descent into the pit to an animal sent to slaughter. Details like the goat killed for its blood and Potiphar, captain of the butchers, give shape to this image.
- Through repetition of key vocabulary, the biblical authors link Yoseph's betrayal with the binding of Isaac.
- Human evil leads to the death of the beloved one, but God provides a *takhat* (a substitute, one who stands in the place of another).

Paragraph 3: Genesis 37:31-36

³¹ And they took **the robe** of Yoseph,
and they **slaughtered** a **hairy goat**,
and they dipped **the robe** in the blood,
³² and they sent **the robe** of many colors,
and they brought it to **their father**.

And they said,
"We found this!
Recognize it, please!
Is it **the robe** of **your son**, or not?"
³³ And he **recognized it**,
and he said,
"**The robe** of **my son**!
A terrible **animal** ate him!
Yoseph has certainly been torn apart!"

³⁴ And Ya'akov tore **his clothes**,
and he placed **sackcloth** on his thighs,
and **he grieved over his son** for many days.
³⁵ And all his sons and all his daughters got up to **comfort** him,
and he refused to be **comforted**,
and he said,

“Surely, I will go down to **my son**, **grieving**, to She’ol!”
 And **his father wept for him**,
 36 but as for the **Medanim**, they sold him to Egypt,
 to Potiphar, official of Phar’oh,
 captain of the **butchers** .

Genesis 37:31-36. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

The Deceptive Animal (Garment)

Adam and Eve are deceived by a spiritual being who takes up the animal disguise of a snake, and so they end up clothed with the skin of an animal and exiled from Eden ([Gen. 3](#)).

Yaaqov put on the skin of a slaughtered goat in order to deceive his father and gain the blessing, only to find himself exiled from Canaan ([Gen. 27](#)).

Yoseph loses his royal robe, his brothers smear it with the blood of a slaughtered goat to deceive their father, and Yoseph finds himself exiled from Canaan ([Gen. 37](#)).

A Beloved Son and a Slaughtered Goat

Notice how the cloak, bloodied by a slaughtered goat, becomes a twisted image of Yoseph’s status as the beloved son who was supposed to be elevated to a place of rule and honor among the brothers.

The capture and sale of Yoseph is replete with language from the Aqedah in [Genesis 22](#), which is full of ironic inversions and twists.

Yaaqov, Yoseph, and a Goat in Genesis 37	Avraham, Yitskhaq, and a Ram in Genesis 22
Gen. 37:3 Yoseph is Yaaqov’s “son of old age” (בן זקנים), whom he loves (אהב) more than his brothers.	Gen. 21:2, 7; 22:2 Yitskhaq is Avraham’s “son of old age” (בן לזקניו), whom he loves (אהב)
Gen. 37:13 Yaaqov calls for Yoseph, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)”	Gen. 22:1 God calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)” Gen. 22:7 Yitskhaq calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)” Gen. 22:11 The Angel of Yahweh calls for Avraham, “and he said, ‘Here I am’ (הנני)”
Rams and Goats in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Yaaqov, Yoseph, and a Goat in Genesis 37	Avraham, Yitskhaq, and a Ram in Genesis 22
Gen. 37:18 "And they [the brothers] saw (ראה) him [Yoseph] from afar (מרחק) "	Gen. 22:4 "And Avraham saw (ראה) the place from afar (מרחק) "
Gen. 37:20 "Let's say an evil beast ate him (אכל) ..." Gen. 37:24-25 "And they took him (לקח) ... and they sat down to eat (אכל) bread ..."	Gen. 22:6 "And Avraham took (לקח) ... the knife/eater (מאכלת) "
Gen. 37:22 Reuven to brothers: " Don't send out a hand against him (ויד אל תשלחו בו)" Gen. 37:27 Yehudah to brothers: " And our hand, don't let it be against him (וידני אל תהי בו)"	Gen. 22:10 "And Avraham sent out his hand (וישלח ... את ידו) and he took the knife ..." Gen. 22:12 Angel to Avraham: " Don't send out your hand against the lad (אל תשלח ידך אל הנער)"
Gen. 37:25 The brothers "lifted their eyes and looked, and behold, Yishmaelites"	Gen. 22:4 "And Avraham lifted his eyes and looked at the place from afar." Gen. 22:13 "And Avraham lifted his eyes and looked, and behold, a ram afar, caught in the thicket."
Gen. 37:31-32 The brothers take a goat and slay it (שחט) as a substitute for their brother, and bring its blood to their father.	Gen. 22:10, 13 Avraham is about to slay (שחט) his son, but is able to offer a ram "as a substitute for his son"
<i>Rams and Goats in Genesis. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The affinities of the Yoseph story with the binding of Isaac in Genesis 22 are striking, though the relationship is one of inversion in some important respects.

- Abraham intends to slay Isaac, who is spared in the nick of time. // Yaaqov intends to send and receive his son back soon but finds that he has been "slain."
- Abraham offers the sacrificial ram in place of his son. // For Yaaqov, the goat and its blood take the place of the son, because he has (so Yaaqov thinks) been mauled to death. The slain goat symbolizes the loss of the beloved son.
- Abraham intends to lose his son and receives him back. // Yaaqov intends to receive back his son and loses him.

But alongside these inversions, there are also profound continuities.

- For Yaaqov's beloved son, his death is only symbolized; in reality he has been "spared" from literal death. The goat dies and the son lives to be later restored to his father.
- The son who undergoes symbolic death is the firstborn of his father's preferred wife (just as Isaac is to Sarah).
- Yoseph's words to Yaaqov "here I am" ([Gen. 37:13](#)) echo Abraham's response to God ([Gen. 22:1, 11](#)), as well as Esau's response to Isaac in [Genesis 27:1](#).

"In a sense, the two stories of Abraham and Isaac and that of Isaac and Jacob flow together in the story of Jacob and Joseph."

Levenson, Jon D. (1995). [The Death and Resurrection of the Beloved Son](#). Yale University Press. 149.

Yoseph Assaulted, Slaughtered, Exiled, Enslaved, and Thrown in the Grave

[Genesis 37](#) creates a network of images and vocabulary to describe Yoseph's fate, some of them real and others imagined. But their association in this opening story connects them in an important way, and we find them repeated and connected even more as the story develops.

- Yoseph is thrown into a pit ([בֹּרַח](#)) ([Gen. 37:20, 22, 24, 28, 29](#)).
- Yoseph is abused by his brothers ([Gen. 37:23](#)).
- Yoseph is substituted for a slaughtered animal ([Gen. 37:31-32](#)).
- Yoseph is sold into slavery ([Gen. 37:28-29](#)).
- Yaaqov assumes that Yoseph is "torn up," "eaten," and "in the grave" ([Gen. 37:33, 35](#)).

This network of associations provides the most robust portrait of human evil and violence that we've encountered thus far in Genesis. These images will be drawn upon throughout the Hebrew Bible, especially to describe David's dangerous trials in the Psalms ([Ps. 69](#)).

Psalm 69:1-2, 4, 8-9, 14-15 Instructor's Translation

¹ Save me, O God,
for the waters have threatened my life.

² I have sunk in deep mire, and there is no foothold;
I have come into deep waters, and a flood overflows me. ...

⁴ Those who hate me without a cause are more than the hairs of my head;
those who would destroy me are powerful, being wrongfully my enemies;
what I did not steal, I then have to restore. ...

⁸ I have become estranged from my brothers,
and a foreigner to my mother's sons.

⁹ For zeal for your house has consumed me,
and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me. ...

¹⁴ Deliver me from the mire and do not let me sink;
may I be delivered from my foes and from the deep waters.

¹⁵ May the flood of water not overflow me,
nor the deep swallow me up,
nor the pit shut its mouth on me.

Reflection Question

How do the biblical authors subtly foreshadow the hopeful deliverance coming at the end of the Yoseph story as the brothers cast Yoseph into the pit?